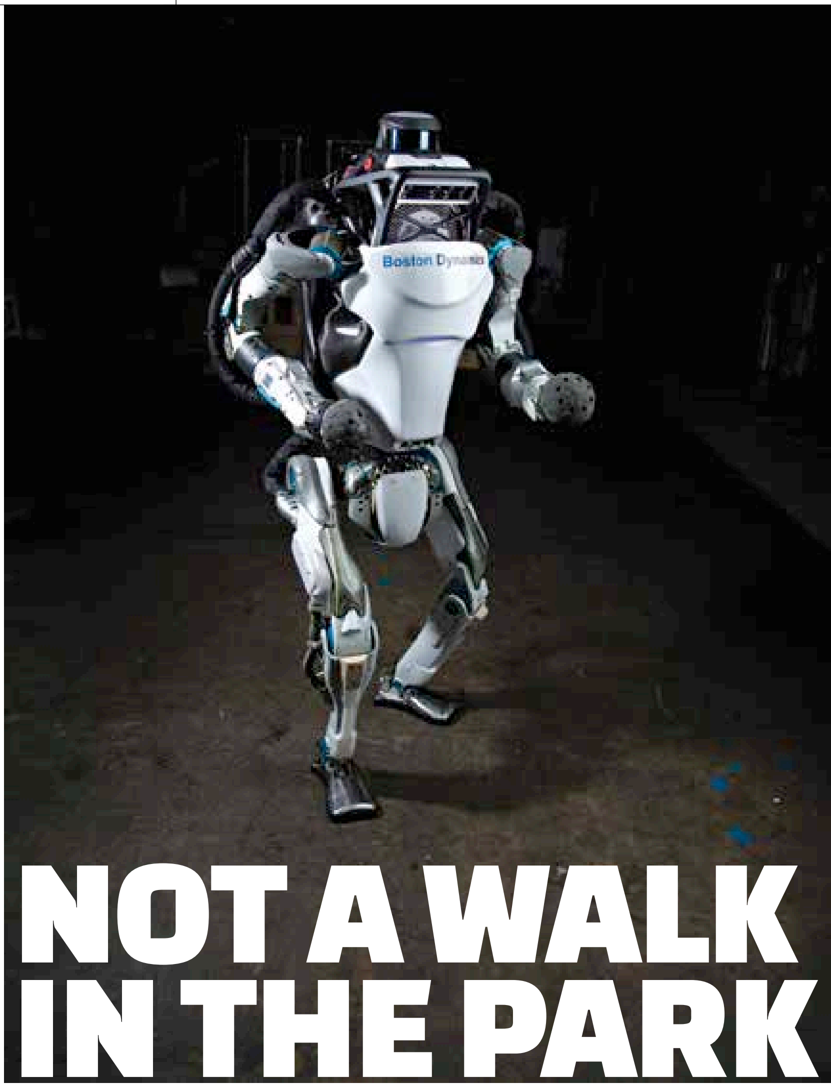
China cracks down on Bitcoin
The Chinese government has asked local governements to ensure shutdown of cryptocurrency farms. **http://dgit.in/ChinaNoBTC**

Drone lifts refrigerator
Boeing has unveiled a new drone that can lift up to 500 pounds of cargo, that's most refrigerators. **http://dgit.in/DroneBro**



NOT A WALK IN THE PARK

How close are we to building a robot that moves like us?

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The promises of robotics is to reduce the need for humans to do repeated, menial or dangerous jobs. Applications range from agriculture to manufacturing to transport. For many of these applications, it is not necessary for the robots to resemble the humans. The robots can grow, shrink, crawl, fly, roll, sail or glide in their efforts to navigate the environment and perform the task at hand. Shapeshifting robots can even shift from one form to another. The arms used to manipulate objects do not need to look like human limbs. Research and current engineering trends suggest that in the future, robots will not resemble humans at all. This is because humans are simply too inefficient. Dr Simon Watson, a lecturer in Robotic Systems at the University of Manchester says, "Humanoid robots are a vanity project: an attempt to create artificial life in our own image – essentially trying to play God. The problem is, we're not very good at it. Ask someone on the street to name a robot and you might hear "Terminator", "the Cybermen" or "that gold one from Star Wars".

There are reasons we do need androids, or robots that resemble humans in appearance. One reason is for providing assistance to those with impaired mobility, or disabilities. The technologies developed for these kinds of robots can also have applications in prosthetics. Robots that care for the elderly, young children, or for use in the service industry stand to benefit by appearing human, even more so if they are cute. While the human form factor might not be very efficient when it comes to doing one kind of task, it is pretty versatile.

In the immediate aftermath of the Fukushima Daiichi nuclear disaster, humans could not go back into the plant because of how dangerous the area was. However, if a robot entered the plant and turned the cooling system back on, the extent of the damage caused by the reactor meltdown could have been significantly reduced. The disaster urged DARPA to spur innovation towards a robot that could have mitigated the disaster. The DARPA robotics challenge had a series of tasks for robots to perform, including driving a vehicle, climbing a ladder, opening a door, connect a hose pipe and breaking through a concrete panel. While some robots in the challenge used tank tracks or had four legs, most were bipedal.

ROBOTIC BIPEDALISM

We really are not good at building bipedal robots. Robots are not even smart enough to stand up yet. The most advanced humanoid robots tend to fall over when performing simple tasks such as climbing stairs, opening a door, or even walking. This is even difficult to accomplish when the robots are given four legs. A significant portion of the research into humanoid robotics is dedicated to just keeping them upright. In fact, researchers at Georgia Tech are looking into training robots to fall gracefully, in a manner that causes as little damage as possible to the robot, as well as others. This can help reduce the costs of repair, and is an important skill when it comes to robots working with the injured, children, elderly or pets.

The biomimetics robotic laboratory at MIT is developing a robot called HERMES to respond to disaster situations. The idea is to keep a human in